perplexity

What if they ask why it did not go to production

Answer honestly and strategically: explain the **specific blocker**, show that you understood why production requires more than a working prototype, and describe what you would do next. Do not apologize as if the project failed—prototypes are meant to validate feasibility before an organization invests in security, integration, governance, and operations. [1] [2] [3]

Use this answer formula

"It was intentionally scoped as a prototype to validate [problem/approach]. It is not in production because [specific blocker]. I understood that production would require [security/data/integration/monitoring work], and my next step would be [concrete plan]."

This shows business awareness, not just coding ability. A proof of concept proves technical feasibility; production requires governed data, real user access, security review, monitoring, ownership, and a support model. [2] [4] [5]

Answers for your projects

Python CSV migration app

> "It was built as an internal prototype to validate the migration workflow and demonstrate that we could automate CSV ingestion, validation, staging, and archiving. It has not gone to production yet because it needs formal approval around data access, scheduling, error-handling standards, and integration with the team's existing operational process.
> Before production, I would add centralized logging, role-based access, retry and recovery handling, a proper scheduler, and reconciliation reports. I would also align it with the data team's governance and deployment standards. The prototype proved the workflow was feasible; productionization is mainly about making it secure, monitored, and operationally owned."

This is a strong answer because data migration tools need validation, auditability, access controls, and operational ownership before production use. [3] [6] [7]

RAG chatbot

> “I built it as a proof of concept to test whether a locally hosted Phi-4 model could answer questions from internal documents with useful, source-grounded responses. It is not in production because we would need security and compliance review, controlled access to approved documents, evaluation on a broader set of real questions, and monitoring for answer quality and hallucinations.
> For production, I would add authentication and role-based document permissions, audit logging, a larger evaluation dataset, human feedback, and guardrails for sensitive or out-of-scope questions. I would also define acceptance criteria—such as groundedness, retrieval accuracy, latency, and refusal behavior—before rollout.”

This is especially credible in reinsurance, where sensitive documents, access permissions, audit trails, and human oversight are major production concerns. [8] [9] [1]

AI regression-testing app

> “It is currently in progress, so it has not reached production by design. I am first building and validating the core workflow: defining test cases, executing checks, comparing results against a baseline, and reporting regressions.
> To make it production-ready, I would integrate it into CI/CD, add authentication and role-based access, support multiple application types, and establish clear quality thresholds and ownership for maintaining the test suite. The prototype phase is helping me validate which checks are reliable and which need human review.”

This positions an incomplete project as a deliberate, staged rollout rather than a failure. [4] [10] [11]

If the real reason was prioritization

Many prototypes stop because the business prioritized something else. Say that plainly, without blaming anyone:

> “The prototype successfully demonstrated the approach, but the team’s immediate priorities shifted to another initiative, so it was not taken forward for a formal pilot at that time. I documented the architecture, limitations, and production requirements so it could be picked up later. It also helped me understand what a production rollout would require.”

This is professional and shows ownership. Avoid saying “management did not support it” or “the company is slow.” Instead, frame it as competing priorities and unclear production ownership—common reasons AI pilots stall. [5] [2] [3]

If data access or security was the blocker

> “The initial version used controlled/sample data so I could validate the workflow quickly. Production would require approved access to sensitive business data, security review, data-lineage documentation, and role-based permissions. I intentionally avoided using sensitive data prematurely before those controls and approvals were in place.”

This is an excellent answer in a regulated reinsurance environment. Using synthetic, masked, or limited data until governance approvals exist is a recommended practice, not a weakness. [12] [1] [8]

If evaluation was incomplete

> "The prototype showed that the core approach works, but I would not call it production-ready until I had a larger, representative evaluation set and clear quality thresholds. For example, for the RAG assistant, I would measure retrieval accuracy, groundedness, hallucination rate, refusal behavior, and latency before rollout."

This demonstrates engineering maturity: you distinguish "the demo works" from "the system is reliable enough to deploy." [10] [13] [4]

What not to say

Avoid these answers:

- "The company is too slow."
- "Nobody supported my project."
- "I did not have time."
- "It was just a demo."
- "It works, so it should be in production."
- "I don't know why it was not deployed."

Also avoid claiming production deployment or user adoption that did not happen. Interviewers value clarity about your individual contribution and the project's actual status. [14] [15] [16]

Strong closing line

End with initiative:

> "I see the prototype as the first stage. The next step is to turn it into a small pilot with defined success metrics, stakeholder feedback, security controls, and a monitoring plan. That is the work I would want to own."

This turns the question from "Why did it fail?" into "What would you do to make it production-ready?"—which is exactly the mindset enterprise AI teams need. [9] [2] [5]

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